

Customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors: Test of a social exchange model of antecedents

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Abstract

Using a sample of 281 frontline service employees of a national retail bank, we test a social exchange model of antecedents of three dimensions of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors suggested by prior boundary-spanning and services marketing/management literatures: external representation, internal influence, and service delivery. In support of our hypotheses, we identify fully mediated relationships from procedural, interactional, and distributive justice to external representation and internal influence via job satisfaction and organizational commitment. Our results generally support our expectation that the indirect effects of procedural justice on external representation and internal influence are stronger than the indirect effects of distributive or interactional justice on these behaviors. Also, our results reveal no significant indirect effects of procedural and distributive justice on service delivery behaviors. However, we find an unexpected direct positive path from interactional justice to service delivery behaviors. We interpret this latter finding in light of the normative value of interactional justice as a source of role modeling or managerial legitimacy.

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Over the past two decades, both academics and practitioners have asserted a “spillover” effect between employee attitudes such as justice perceptions, job satisfaction, and organizational commitment and customers’ satisfaction and service quality perceptions (cf. Bowen, Gilliland, & Folger 1999). Empirical research has generally provided support for these assertions across service industries (cf. Bernhardt, Donthu, & Kennett 2000; Hartline & Ferrell 1996), and firms have adopted slogans such as “People-Service-Profits” to express their confidence in these linkages. Other research reveals that prosocial behaviors of frontline service employees (FSEs), including discretionary service- or customer-oriented behaviors, help to explain the spillover effects of employee attitudes on customer outcomes (Bell & Menguc 2002; Bettencourt & Brown 1997).

Despite the need for studies to better understand how and why distinct employee attitudes are related to various FSE prosocial behaviors, at least three important concerns with prior research limit our understanding. First, despite repeated calls for consideration of prosocial behaviors tailored to the unique job demands and work context of customer service employees (cf. Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Paine, & Bachrach 2000), most research on boundary-spanning service employees has only investigated prosocial behaviors such as traditional organizational citizenship behaviors (OCBs) that are equally applicable across jobs and contexts (cf. Bell & Menguc 2002). Second, although past research provides a clear indication of the relevance of applying social exchange theory to the study of relationships among employee attitudes and prosocial behaviors (cf. MacKenzie, Podsakoff, & Ahearne 1998), this research has not generally investigated the range of employee attitudes we consider. For example, studies of prosocial behavior antecedents have often not included distributive, procedural, and interactional justice perceptions simultaneously or have not included both job satisfaction and organizational commitment with justice per-

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